

The Instability Itself Is the Institution: Ministerial Survival and Institutional Learning in Peru, 1821–2026

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Abstract

Why do political systems that change so much change so little in how they govern? This paper addresses that question through an original dataset of 1,062 ministerial spells covering five portfolios in Peru from 1821 to 2026. Rather than treating ministerial duration as the outcome to be explained, we treat it as a signal: an observable trace of the continuity conditions under which governing experience either accumulates into institutional knowledge or is repeatedly lost. We organize the analysis around two analytical heuristics. The first is the institutional epoch — the path-dependent period between critical junctures — which captures whether successive historical ruptures produced durable improvements in continuity conditions. The second is the protective belt — a localized architecture of external accountability relationships that, where it exists, insulates certain ministries from the political logic governing the rest of the cabinet. Kaplan–Meier survival curves, log-rank tests, and Cox proportional hazards models show that epochs explain ministerial survival far better than individual traits or portfolio membership, and that continuity conditions did not improve monotonically across two centuries. The largest shift in the data occurred between the Oligarchic State and the Power-Sharing epoch; the most recent democratic period represents a partial regression toward the founding pattern of chronic interruption. The protective belt emerges only after 1993, when external accountability structures raised the cost of Economy minister replacement beyond what domestic political pressure alone could sustain. The central theoretical finding is that chronic ministerial instability in Peru is not evidence of absent institutions but of a durable informal one: the escape valve through which political pressure is absorbed without producing structural change. The instability itself is the institution.

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“Se vogliamo che tutto rimanga
com’è, bisogna che tutto cambi.”

Il Gattopardo
Giuseppe Tomasi di Lampedusa,
1958

Introduction

Governing is hard. Education, health, public safety, and economic development are not technical problems with known solutions, but complex social challenges that demand sustained institutional effort. Good policy takes time to design, time to implement, and even longer to produce visible social outcomes. Good practices diffuse gradually. Organizations accumulate knowledge slowly. Institutional learning emerges only when that accumulated knowledge is preserved, transmitted, and refined across successive administrations. Citizens experience meaningful change only after years of coherent action in the same direction. In the long run, successful governance depends less on isolated political decisions than on the organizational conditions that allow knowledge to persist beyond individual officeholders.

After more than two hundred years of republican life, the Peruvian political class has repeatedly changed governments, cabinets, constitutions, and political coalitions. Yet the underlying pattern remains remarkably stable. Each new administration appoints a cabinet whose members understand, implicitly or explicitly, the

terms of their engagement: they are expected to manage complexity on behalf of the president, but they may also be sacrificed whenever political pressure demands a visible response. Their departure rarely resolves the conflict that triggered it. The resignation of a premier or any other minister may relieve immediate pressure, but it seldom addresses the underlying causes of crisis. Cabinet reshuffles therefore signal political responsiveness without necessarily producing institutional correction.

This persistence should not be mistaken for an absence of adaptation. Political actors continuously learn how to navigate constitutional ambiguities, manage public blame, and deploy ministerial replacement as a mechanism for absorbing political pressure. If the political class has accumulated any expertise, it has largely been in reproducing established responses to crisis rather than transforming the institutional conditions that generate those crises. Governments change. Ministers change. Yet the repertoire through which instability is managed remains remarkably stable. This cycle has characterized much of Peru's republican history.

Political scientists often describe this type of persistence through the concept of path dependence, whereby accumulated institutional choices progressively constrain subsequent alternatives. Yet paths do break. Roman Krznaric (2024) argues that transformative institutional change requires what he calls a *disruption nexus*: a major crisis, social movements capable of amplifying that crisis, and a compelling institutional idea ready to occupy the political space created by disruption. France's Fifth Republic illustrates this dynamic. The Algerian War provided the crisis, Gaullism supplied the political movement, and constitutional redesign centered on a strong executive offered the institutional solution. The resulting transformation was not the product of a single event but the culmination of decades of unresolved executive instability. More importantly, it fundamentally altered the conditions under which political continuity was produced. The legacy of the Fifth Republic was therefore not merely institutional reform, but a durable change in the patterns of executive stability that had characterized French politics for more than a century.

Prior to the Fifth Republic, France exhibited levels of executive instability comparable to those observed throughout much of Peru's republican history. Figure 1 illustrates this similarity. Peru reached twenty-three premier appointments during the 1890s, while France reached twenty during the 1930s. After 1958, however, the trajectories diverged sharply. French premier appointments declined to a stable range of three to six per decade and have remained there ever since, whereas Peru has gradually returned to levels characteristic of the nineteenth century. Peru has experienced no shortage of potential disruption nexuses—or, as they will later be conceptualized in this paper, critical junctures: independence without effective state-building, the War of the Pacific, hyperinflation, political violence, the collapse of the Fujimori regime, and the prolonged constitutional crisis beginning in 2016. Each represented a historical moment in which alternative institutional trajectories became plausible.

The central question, however, is not whether institutional change occurred.

Peru's republican history is full of constitutional reforms, regime transitions, and political ruptures. The more fundamental question is whether these transformations altered the organizational conditions under which knowledge could be preserved, accumulated, and transmitted over time. From this perspective, a critical juncture matters not simply because it generates new institutional arrangements, but because it may establish a durable political framework capable of reshaping the conditions under which organizations accumulate knowledge and governments learn. France appears to have experienced such a transformation after 1958. Peru's trajectory raises the possibility that institutional innovation and organizational learning do not necessarily coincide.

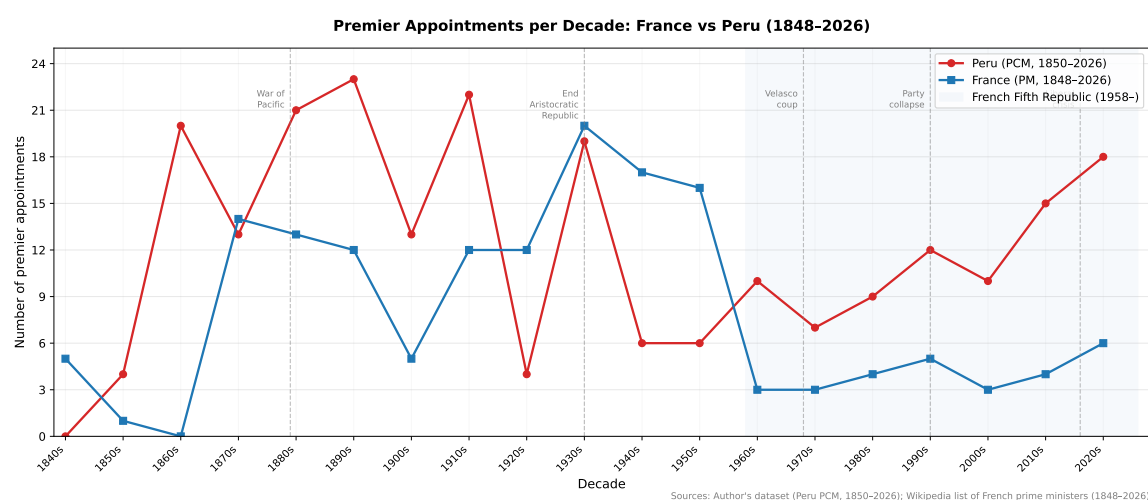


Figure 1

Premier Appointments per Decade: France vs. Peru, 1848–2026.

Sources: Author's dataset (based on Gálvez Montero and García Vega (2016a, 2016b)); Wikipedia list of French prime ministers (1848–2026).

This paper approaches that question through ministerial continuity. Ministerial duration is not interpreted as evidence of organizational learning itself. Rather, it constitutes observable evidence about the organizational conditions under which knowledge may accumulate. Organizations do not preserve knowledge because particular individuals remain indefinitely in office. Instead, sustained continuity creates opportunities for organizational routines, institutional memory, policy procedures, and accumulated expertise to be retained and transmitted despite inevitable personnel turnover. Ministerial continuity therefore represents a necessary—although not sufficient—condition for organizational knowledge accumulation.

Political science has traditionally examined these issues through separate research traditions. Ministerial duration has been analyzed using survival and event-history methods, whereas long-term institutional development has largely been studied through the comparative-historical literature on path dependence and critical

junctures. This paper connects these traditions by reconceptualizing ministerial continuity as an observable indicator of the organizational conditions required for knowledge accumulation and institutional learning.

The empirical strategy follows two complementary heuristics derived from the theoretical framework developed below. The first examines variation in ministerial continuity across historically distinct political frameworks in order to evaluate how opportunities for organizational knowledge accumulation changed over time. The second compares continuity across ministerial portfolios operating within the same political framework, recognizing that some organizations may become partially insulated from the broader political dynamics affecting the cabinet as a whole. Together, these perspectives distinguish historical variation from organizational variation in the conditions under which organizational knowledge may accumulate.

The question guiding this study is straightforward: *Have Peru’s successive political frameworks generated different opportunities for the accumulation of organizational knowledge?*

This question cannot be answered directly because organizational knowledge is not directly observable in historical records. Instead, the analysis evaluates the necessary organizational condition under which knowledge may accumulate: continuity. If organizational continuity constitutes a prerequisite for knowledge accumulation, then systematic differences in ministerial continuity should reveal systematic differences in the opportunities available for organizations to preserve, accumulate, and transmit knowledge over time.

The theoretical framework translates this general question into three empirical questions. *First*, what continuity conditions characterized Peru’s successive political frameworks? *Second*, did those continuity conditions differ systematically across political frameworks? *Third*, within the same political framework, did some ministerial portfolios systematically exhibit greater continuity than others?

To answer these questions, we construct an original dataset of individual ministerial spells covering the period from 1821 to 2026. The analysis focuses on five portfolios that capture distinct organizational functions within the executive branch. The Presidency of the Council of Ministers (PCM) represents the political center responsible for coordinating cabinet action and maintaining executive cohesion. The Ministry of Economy and Finance (MEF) represents the technocratic center responsible for fiscal and macroeconomic policy. The Ministries of Interior, Health, and Education represent policy sectors confronting some of Peru’s most persistent governance challenges according to official yearly surveys (INEI, 2024). Ministerial spells are subsequently organized into historically distinct political frameworks derived from Peru’s critical junctures (Lopez Jimenez et al., 2025). Combining descriptive analyses with survival models, the study evaluates how organizational continuity varied across political frameworks and ministerial portfolios, thereby providing empirical evidence about the organizational conditions under which knowledge accumulation becomes possible.

1 Literature Review

The political science literature on ministerial survival has converged around two broad families of explanations. The first explains variation in ministerial tenure through characteristics of ministers themselves. The second emphasizes the political and institutional environments within which ministers operate. Table 1 summarizes the principal covariates identified across the core studies.

Table 1

Trait-based and Context-based Predictors of Ministerial Survival

Author(s)	Trait-based	Context-based
Blondel (1988)	Career duration; parliamentary vs. managerial profile	Party system norms; head-of-government style; country context
Huber & Martinez-Gallardo (2008)	Ideological distance from government center; PM party membership; portfolio importance	Coalition type; minority government; electoral volatility; party fractionalization
Dewan & Dowding (2005)	Resignation issue salience; ministerial seniority	PM support level; media attention; single-party vs. coalition system
Fischer et al. (2012)	Age; education; gender; portfolio rank	PM popularity; regime type; frequency of resignation calls
Camerlo & Pérez-Liñán (2015)	Portfolio type; technocrat/partisan/outsider profile; first cabinet appointment	Protests; scandals; electoral calendar; term limits; reelection rules
Camerlo & Castaldo (2024)	Partisan rank within party hierarchy (leader, high-rank, low-rank, newcomer, shadow, defector)	Party government model applicability; regime type; party institutionalization level
Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian (2023)	Technical expertise; presidential group membership; prior electoral experience (<i>risk factor</i>)	Economic growth; GDP per capita; legislative powers; regime type; portfolio area
Mejía et al. (2021)	Education; gender; regional origin; prior elected office	Coalition type; legislative majority; party-system change
Alexiadou & Gunaydin (2019)	Technocratic profile; non-partisan status; reform commitment	Economic crisis severity; electoral system type; party control of portfolio
Baturo & Elkink (2014)	Personal traits as time-invariant officeholder effects (education, prior career)	Regime institutionalization; personalization vs. office-based authority
Jara Iñiguez & Cedeño Alcívar (2019)	Managerial performance lifecycle (inverted-U over tenure)	Presidential appointment and dismissal capacity; political trust as selection criterion

1.1 Trait-Based Explanations of Ministerial Survival

Trait-based approaches explain ministerial survival through characteristics of the officeholder. Across different institutional settings, scholars have shown that ministers' professional backgrounds, political careers, partisan affiliations, and personal resources influence their probability of remaining in office. Early studies emphasized broad distinctions between managerial and parliamentary profiles, as well as the effects of career trajectories and prior political experience (Blondel, 1988). Subsequent work expanded the range of relevant characteristics to include age, education, gender, portfolio rank, and seniority within government (Dewan & Dowding, 2005; Fischer et al., 2012).

More recent research has refined these categories by focusing on the organizational and political resources that ministers bring to office. Feliú Ribeiro and

López Burian show that technical expertise and membership in presidential networks increase ministerial survival, while prior electoral experience may paradoxically operate as a risk factor (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023). Across four Latin American countries between 1945 and 2020, career politicians proved more vulnerable to dismissal than technocrats. The finding suggests that ministerial value cannot be reduced to political experience alone; survival depends on the type of resources political leaders seek to preserve.

The literature has also moved beyond simple dichotomies between partisan and non-partisan ministers. Camerlo and Castaldo argue that partisan affiliation conceals substantial variation in the strength of a minister's relationship with the party organization. Their framework distinguishes among leaders, high-ranks, low-ranks, newcomers, shadows, and defectors according to levels of engagement, consolidation, and hierarchical position within the party (Camerlo & Castaldo, 2024). Applied to the Argentine cabinet under Alberto Fernández, this approach reveals that apparently strong partisan cabinets may actually consist of ministers with limited organizational leverage over their parties (Camerlo et al., 2024). Ministers sharing the same partisan label therefore possess very different capacities to withstand political pressure.

Taken together, these studies demonstrate that ministerial duration is shaped by who ministers are. Technical expertise, organizational embeddedness, political experience, and personal resources all influence survival prospects. Yet the effects of these traits depend fundamentally on the environments in which ministers operate. The same characteristic may be rewarded in one institutional setting and penalized in another. This observation leads naturally to the second major family of explanations.

1.2 Context-Based Explanations of Ministerial Survival

Context-based approaches explain ministerial survival through characteristics of the political environment rather than characteristics of individual ministers. Ministers survive or fail because of the institutional and political constraints surrounding them.

The comparative literature consistently identifies coalition dynamics as a central determinant of ministerial duration. Coalition type, minority government status, electoral volatility, and party-system fragmentation all shape the likelihood of ministerial replacement independently of individual characteristics (Huber & Martinez-Gallardo, 2008). Similarly, political crises, scandals, protests, electoral calendars, and term limits alter the incentives presidents face when deciding whether to retain or dismiss ministers (Alexiadou & Gunaydin, 2019; Camerlo & Pérez-Liñán, 2015). Even macroeconomic performance influences survival probabilities by modifying the broader political environment within which governments operate (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023).

The case literature illustrates these mechanisms particularly clearly. For Colombia, Mejía Guinand et al. find that although individual characteristics matter, the institutional configuration of the political system ultimately determines the

range within which those characteristics can operate (Mejía et al., 2021). Constitutional reforms, changes in party-system structure, and coalition arrangements alter the political logic governing ministerial careers. Similar conclusions emerge from Chile, where Avendaño and Dávila show that ministerial turnover during the Concertación governments was driven primarily by coalition management rather than by individual performance. Finance ministers consistently exhibited the longest tenures regardless of their personal characteristics (Avendaño & Dávila, 2012).

Recent work has also refined the contextual analysis of ministerial portfolios. Portfolio importance has traditionally been measured through expert rankings that assign ministries a single level of salience. Camerlo and Martínez-Gallardo argue that such measures obscure important differences among ministries, particularly in contexts characterized by weak party institutionalization (Camerlo & Gallardo, 2022). Their framework decomposes ministerial value into policy-management capacity, discretionary resource allocation, political agenda influence, and inter-portfolio coordination authority. Different political environments activate different dimensions of portfolio value, producing distinct survival incentives for presidents and ministers alike.

Taken together, these studies demonstrate that ministerial survival depends not only on who ministers are but also on where they operate. Institutional structures, coalition arrangements, political crises, economic conditions, and portfolio characteristics jointly define the opportunities and constraints governing ministerial careers.

1.3 Reinterpreting Ministerial Continuity

The two families of explanations are not competing research programs. Virtually every empirical study combines individual and contextual covariates, with political environments conditioning the effects of ministerial characteristics. Together, these studies provide a rich understanding of why some ministers survive longer than others.

Despite their differences, however, they share an implicit assumption: ministerial duration is itself the phenomenon to be explained. Consequently, continuity is interpreted primarily as the outcome of cabinet management, coalition bargaining, institutional constraints, or individual characteristics. This common orientation leaves unexplored a different analytical possibility. Rather than asking why ministers remain in office, ministerial continuity may be interpreted as observable evidence about the organizational conditions under which governments preserve accumulated knowledge and develop institutional learning.

This paper adopts that alternative perspective. Ministerial continuity is not treated as evidence of organizational learning itself, nor does it imply that knowledge resides in individual ministers. Rather, continuity provides the organizational condition under which knowledge embedded in routines, procedures, institutional memory, and accumulated administrative experience can be preserved, transmitted, and refined over time despite inevitable personnel turnover. Organizations, not individuals,

are therefore the principal unit through which knowledge accumulates.

This reinterpretation shifts the analytical focus from explaining individual ministerial survival to understanding the organizational conditions that make institutional learning possible. Instead of treating ministerial duration as a dependent variable, the paper treats patterns of continuity as empirical evidence about the capacity of political organizations to preserve and accumulate knowledge across successive governments.

The next section develops a deductive theoretical framework organized around two axioms and three propositions. The first axiom establishes organizational continuity as the necessary condition for organizational knowledge accumulation. The second identifies organizational knowledge accumulation as the necessary condition for institutional learning. Building upon these foundations, the propositions explain why continuity varies across political frameworks, how political frameworks generate different configurations of organizational protection, and why those protective arrangements produce differentiated continuity across ministerial portfolios. Together, these axioms and propositions provide the conceptual foundation for interpreting ministerial continuity as observable evidence about the organizational conditions under which knowledge accumulation and institutional learning become possible.

2 Theoretical Framework

The theoretical framework developed in this paper follows an axiomatic–deductive strategy. Rather than beginning with hypotheses to be statistically tested, it begins with two foundational axioms concerning the organizational conditions under which political institutions accumulate knowledge and learn over time. These axioms are treated as conceptual premises. They are not themselves subjected to empirical testing. Instead, they establish the logical foundations from which three propositions concerning political continuity are deductively derived.

The propositions likewise are not hypotheses in the conventional statistical sense. They describe theoretical regularities implied by the axioms regarding the relationship between political frameworks, organizational protection, and ministerial continuity. Their empirical value lies not in being accepted or rejected through statistical significance, but in generating observable implications against which historical evidence may be interpreted.

Accordingly, the empirical analyses developed later in the paper do not test the propositions themselves. Rather, they examine the extent to which the Peruvian historical trajectory approximates, departs from, or qualifies the patterns implied by the theoretical framework. Statistics therefore serve as tools for interpreting the correspondence between theory and historical evidence, rather than as mechanisms for validating or falsifying the axioms from which the theory is constructed.

Throughout the discussion, arrows ($\rightarrow$) denote heuristic relations of necessary influence within the deductive framework. They indicate logical direction rather than deterministic, linear, or quantitatively specified causal effects.

2.1 Axiom A1: Organizational Knowledge Accumulation Requires Continuity

The first axiom establishes the most fundamental organizational condition of the theoretical framework. Organizations cannot accumulate knowledge unless they preserve sufficient continuity through time. Organizational continuity does not itself generate knowledge, nor does it guarantee effective governance. Rather, it provides the necessary organizational condition under which routines, institutional memory, decision procedures, and accumulated experience may be retained, articulated, transmitted, and progressively refined.

For the purposes of this study, **organizational knowledge accumulation** refers to the process through which experience becomes embedded in organizational routines, procedures, and institutional memory. Knowledge is therefore understood as an organizational property rather than as an attribute of individual officeholders. Ministers may change while organizations continue to preserve and reproduce accumulated knowledge through stable procedures, norms, and administrative practices.

The first axiom is therefore stated as

Organizational Continuity $\rightarrow$ Organizational Knowledge Accumulation
(A1)

Axiom A1 expresses a relation of necessity rather than sufficiency. Organizational continuity creates the opportunity for knowledge accumulation, but continuity alone cannot guarantee that organizations will learn, innovate, or improve. Organizations may remain perfectly stable while repeatedly reproducing ineffective practices. The axiom simply states that without continuity, organizational knowledge cannot accumulate because experience is continually interrupted before it can be retained and incorporated into organizational routines.

Although presented here as a theoretical premise, Axiom A1 is consistent with several independent research traditions.

The organizational learning literature reaches this conclusion by emphasizing that knowledge emerges cumulatively through repeated interaction, articulation, retention, and routinization. Nonaka's theory of organizational knowledge creation conceives knowledge as progressively embedded in organizational routines through continuous interaction among organizational members (Nonaka, 1998). Similarly, Levitt and March argue that organizations learn by encoding experience into routines that persist beyond the individuals who originally generated them (Levitt & March, 1988). Cohen, March, and Olsen arrive at the same conclusion from the opposite direction. Their notion of *organized anarchy* highlights how fluid participation disrupts the organizational continuity required for shared learning and stable organizational memory (Cohen et al., 1972).

The public policy literature independently reinforces the same principle. Simon's theory of bounded rationality argues that complex policy problems become

manageable only through sequential processes of problem structuring and incremental refinement rather than isolated decisions (Foss & Foss, 2005). Lindblom similarly describes policymaking as a cumulative process of successive limited comparisons in which each decision builds upon previous adjustments (Lindblom, 1959). Allison's organizational process model likewise emphasizes that governmental action depends upon routines and standard operating procedures that develop only through organizational continuity (Allison, 1969).

Taken together, these distinct theoretical traditions converge on the same organizational principle despite addressing different substantive questions. Organizational learning explains how knowledge becomes embedded in organizations. Public policy theory explains why effective governing requires sustained engagement with complex problems. Both therefore support the foundational claim expressed by Axiom A1: organizational continuity constitutes the necessary condition under which organizational knowledge may accumulate.

2.2 Axiom A2: Institutional Learning Requires Organizational Knowledge Accumulation

Axiom A1 established organizational continuity as the necessary condition under which organizations accumulate knowledge. A second question naturally follows. Even if organizations accumulate knowledge over time, under what conditions can political institutions themselves be said to learn?

For the purposes of this study, **institutional learning** refers to the historical capacity of political institutions to adapt on the basis of accumulated organizational knowledge. Whereas organizational knowledge accumulation occurs within ministries and other governmental organizations through the preservation of routines, procedures, and institutional memory, institutional learning refers to the broader capacity of political institutions to revise governing practices, adapt organizational arrangements, and improve their performance over time. Institutional learning is therefore understood as an institutional property emerging from organizational processes rather than from the experiences of individual political actors.

The second axiom is therefore stated as

Organizational Knowledge Accumulation $\rightarrow$ Institutional Learning (A2)

Axiom A2 likewise expresses a relation of necessity rather than sufficiency. The accumulation of organizational knowledge creates the opportunity for institutional learning, but it does not guarantee that institutions will adapt successfully or improve their governing capacity. Political institutions may preserve considerable organizational knowledge while continuing to reproduce ineffective routines, inappropriate policies, or maladaptive organizational arrangements. The axiom simply states that institutional learning cannot occur independently of accumulated organizational

knowledge because institutions require an experiential foundation upon which adaptation may occur.

Although presented here as a theoretical premise, Axiom A2 is likewise consistent with several independent theoretical traditions.

The organizational learning literature has long distinguished between the accumulation of experience and organizational learning itself. Fiol and Lyles argue that learning requires more than behavioral adaptation; it involves the development of shared understandings capable of influencing future organizational action (Fiol & Lyles, 1985). Extending this logic to political institutions, Olsen emphasizes that constitutions, laws, organizational routines, and administrative practices function as repositories of accumulated knowledge through which institutions interpret experience and adapt over time (Olsen, 2010). Institutions therefore learn not because individual officeholders remain in office indefinitely, but because organizations preserve and transmit accumulated knowledge across successive generations of political actors.

Political science reaches a similar conclusion through the literature on policy learning. Hall argues that policy paradigms evolve through processes of social learning in which governments revise policy goals, policy instruments, and governing practices on the basis of accumulated experience rather than isolated political events (Hall, 1993). Institutional change therefore reflects learning only when it builds upon organizational knowledge generated through previous experience rather than merely responding to short-term political pressures.

Taken together, these perspectives converge on the same foundational principle despite approaching institutional change from different analytical perspectives. Organizational learning theory explains how accumulated knowledge becomes embedded within organizations. Institutional theory explains how political institutions preserve, interpret, and adapt that accumulated knowledge over time. Both therefore support the principle expressed by Axiom A2: institutional learning presupposes the prior accumulation of organizational knowledge.

Together, Axioms A1 and A2 establish the organizational foundations of the theoretical framework. They are not intended to explain variation across historical contexts. Rather, they define the necessary conditions under which political institutions become capable of learning. The propositions that follow extend these axiomatic foundations by identifying the political mechanisms through which organizational continuity and therefore the opportunity for organizational knowledge accumulation and institutional learning is generated, preserved, or interrupted across different political frameworks.

2.3 Proposition 1: Political Frameworks Shape Organizational Continuity

Axioms A1 and A2 established the organizational foundations of the theoretical framework. Organizational continuity constitutes the necessary condition under which organizations accumulate knowledge, and accumulated organizational knowl-

edge constitutes the necessary condition for institutional learning. These axioms, however, do not explain why continuity itself should vary across history. Proposition 1 addresses this question by introducing the historical environments within which organizations operate.

The central concept proposed here is the **political framework**. A political framework refers to a historically bounded configuration of political institutions, governing arrangements, and actor relationships that structures political action during a particular period. Political frameworks define the broader institutional environment within which governmental organizations operate and therefore establish the conditions under which organizational continuity is either preserved or interrupted.

The concept of political framework is informed by the Critical Juncture tradition of comparative-historical analysis. Rather than viewing political development as a continuous sequence of incremental adjustments, this tradition conceives history as a succession of relatively stable political orders separated by episodes of rapid institutional transformation. Critical junctures establish durable institutional legacies that subsequently structure political action through path-dependent reproduction until another critical juncture generates a new political order (Capoccia & Kelemen, 2007; Collier & Munck, 2022). Within the present framework, these historically distinct political orders are conceptualized as political frameworks.

The first proposition is therefore stated as

Political Framework $\rightarrow$ Organizational Continuity (P1)

Proposition P1 states that different political frameworks generate different conditions for organizational continuity. Unlike the preceding axioms, the proposition is historical rather than organizational. It does not concern how organizations accumulate knowledge, but why the opportunity for organizational continuity itself is expected to differ across historical periods.

Importantly, Proposition P1 makes no assumption regarding the direction of historical development. Successive political frameworks need not become progressively more stable, more efficient, or more conducive to organizational continuity. New political frameworks may preserve, strengthen, weaken, replace, or reverse the organizational conditions inherited from previous periods. The proposition therefore predicts historical variation rather than historical progress.

Because organizational continuity constitutes the necessary condition for organizational knowledge accumulation established by Axiom A1, variation in continuity across political frameworks becomes theoretically consequential. Political frameworks do not produce organizational knowledge directly. Rather, they shape the organizational conditions under which knowledge accumulation and, ultimately, institutional learning become possible.

The observable implication of Proposition P1 is straightforward. If political frameworks structure organizational continuity, then ministerial continuity should not remain constant across history. Instead, historically distinct political frameworks

should exhibit systematically different patterns of ministerial continuity. The empirical analysis developed later evaluates the extent to which the Peruvian historical trajectory approximates this expected regularity.

2.4 Proposition 2: Political Frameworks Generate Protective Belts

Proposition 1 established that political frameworks shape the organizational conditions under which continuity emerges. Continuity, however, need not be distributed uniformly across governmental organizations operating within the same political framework. Political systems assign different strategic importance to different governmental functions, creating incentives to preserve organizational knowledge in some organizations more strongly than in others. Proposition 2 introduces the organizational mechanism through which these political priorities become translated into differentiated continuity conditions.

The central concept proposed here is the **protective belt**¹. A protective belt consists of institutional arrangements that increase the political costs of disrupting organizational continuity. Importantly, protective belts do not protect individual ministers. Ministers may be replaced while organizational routines, policy procedures, institutional memory, and accumulated expertise remain largely intact. The protected object is therefore organizational knowledge rather than individual officeholders.

The second proposition is therefore stated as

$$\text{Political Framework} \rightarrow \text{Protective Belt} \quad (\text{P2})$$

Proposition P2 states that political frameworks generate distinct configurations of protective belts across government. Because political frameworks embody different institutional priorities and governing logics, they need not assign the same strategic importance to the same organizations. Protective belts are therefore not permanent characteristics of particular ministries. Rather, they represent historically contingent organizational arrangements reflecting the priorities embedded within a given political framework.

The proposition follows directly from Proposition 1. If political frameworks shape the conditions under which organizational continuity becomes possible, they may also generate institutional arrangements designed to preserve continuity where organizational knowledge is considered strategically valuable. Protective belts therefore constitute the organizational mechanism linking historical political frameworks to differentiated opportunities for organizational knowledge accumulation.

Although presented here as a theoretical proposition, comparative evidence suggests that similar mechanisms operate in practice. Feliú Ribeiro and López Burian

¹The term *protective belt* is borrowed from Lakatos's philosophy of science, where it denotes the set of auxiliary assumptions that protects the hard core of a research programme from immediate falsification (Lakatos, 1978). The concept is employed here metaphorically. Rather than protecting scientific theories, protective belts protect the organizational conditions under which knowledge can be preserved despite political turnover.

show that foreign affairs portfolios exhibit substantially longer ministerial survival than domestic portfolios across Latin America (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023). They argue that foreign ministers become accountable not only to domestic political actors but also to international audiences, thereby increasing the political costs associated with ministerial replacement. Their findings illustrate how broader political priorities may become translated into organizational arrangements that preserve continuity in strategically important policy domains.

The observable implication of Proposition P2 follows naturally. If political frameworks generate different configurations of protective belts, then organizational continuity should not be distributed uniformly across ministerial portfolios operating within the same political framework. Instead, portfolios occupying strategically protected organizational positions should exhibit systematically greater continuity than portfolios lacking comparable institutional protection.

2.5 Proposition 3: Protective Belts Preserve Organizational Continuity

Proposition P2 established that political frameworks generate distinct configurations of protective belts across governmental organizations. Proposition 3 completes the deductive framework by identifying the organizational consequence of those protective arrangements. If protective belts exist to preserve the organizational conditions under which knowledge accumulates, they should produce differentiated levels of organizational continuity across otherwise comparable organizations operating within the same political framework.

The third proposition is therefore stated as

$$\text{Protective Belt} \rightarrow \text{Organizational Continuity} \quad (\text{P3})$$

Proposition P3 states that stronger protective belts increase organizational continuity by raising the political costs of disrupting organizational arrangements. Importantly, protective belts do not imply that particular ministers remain indefinitely in office. Political leaders retain the authority to appoint and dismiss ministers whenever political circumstances require. Rather, protective belts reduce the frequency with which organizational continuity is disrupted, thereby creating more favorable conditions for preserving organizational routines, institutional memory, policy procedures, and accumulated expertise despite inevitable personnel turnover.

The proposition follows directly from Axiom A1. If organizational continuity constitutes the necessary condition for organizational knowledge accumulation, then political systems seeking to preserve strategically valuable organizational knowledge have incentives to protect continuity in selected governmental organizations. Protective belts therefore operate as organizational mechanisms through which political priorities become translated into differentiated opportunities for knowledge accumulation.

The observable implication of Proposition P3 follows directly. Within the same political framework, governmental organizations protected by stronger protective belts should exhibit systematically greater ministerial continuity than organizations lacking comparable institutional protection. Ministerial continuity is therefore interpreted not as the object of protection itself, but as observable evidence that organizational continuity has been comparatively preserved.

Together, Propositions P1–P3 complete the deductive structure of the theoretical framework. Proposition 1 identifies the historical environments within which organizational continuity is expected to vary. Proposition 2 explains how political frameworks generate different configurations of organizational protection. Proposition 3 explains how those protective arrangements preserve organizational continuity and thereby create differentiated opportunities for organizational knowledge accumulation.

Combined with Axioms A1 and A2, the framework forms a coherent deductive sequence, summarized in Figure 2.

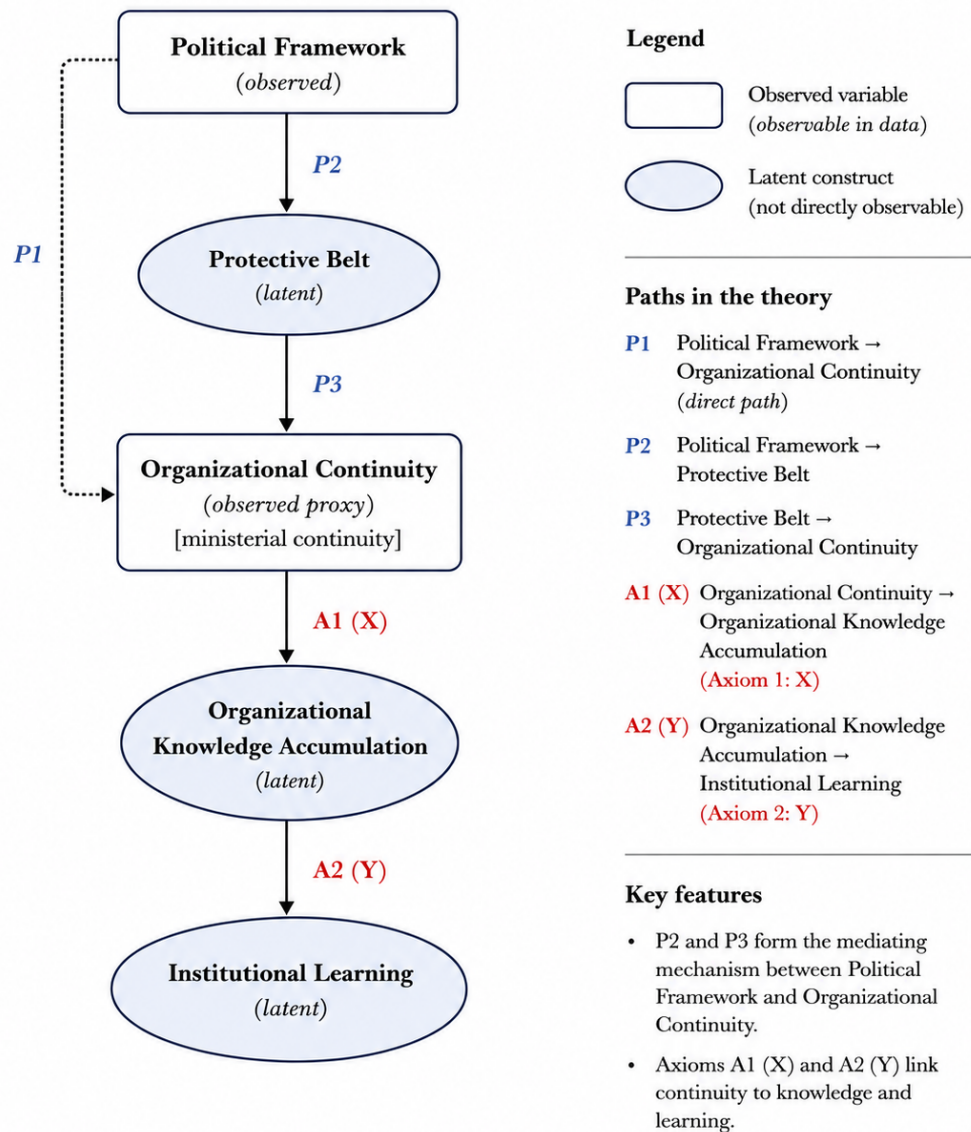
The empirical analyses that follow do not test these propositions directly. Rather, they examine the extent to which Peru’s historical trajectory approximates the observable regularities implied by this deductive framework.

3 Peru as an Empirical Application

The theoretical framework developed in the previous section proposes a general relationship linking political frameworks, organizational continuity, organizational knowledge accumulation, and institutional learning. These concepts are not specific to Peru. They describe organizational processes that may operate in any political system. Peru is therefore introduced not because the theory was derived from the Peruvian experience, but because its republican history provides an unusually informative empirical setting in which the observable implications of the framework can be examined.

Few countries in Latin America have experienced as many profound political transformations while maintaining continuous republican institutions. Since independence, Peru has undergone repeated constitutional reforms, military governments, civil wars, economic collapses, democratic transitions, authoritarian interruptions, and episodes of intense social conflict. Each episode altered the organization of political authority without interrupting the formal continuity of the state. Rather than producing a linear process of institutional improvement, these transformations generated successive political environments characterized by different governing arrangements, organizational priorities, and distributions of political power.

From the perspective adopted here, these historical transformations are analytically important because they potentially altered the organizational conditions under which governmental knowledge could accumulate. The theoretical framework does not assume that institutional reforms necessarily improve governance or generate progressively better political outcomes. Instead, it proposes that different political



Note: P1 implies both a direct effect of Political Framework on Organizational Continuity and an indirect effect through Protective Belt (mediation). A1 (X) and A2 (Y) are axiomatic relationships forming the organizational foundations of institutional learning.

Figure 2

Deductive theoretical framework: axioms and propositions. Rectangles represent observed variables or observed proxies; ellipses represent latent constructs. Arrows indicate theoretical relationships rather than estimated causal effects.

frameworks create different opportunities for preserving organizational continuity and, consequently, different opportunities for organizational knowledge accumulation and institutional learning. Peru therefore provides a particularly useful historical laboratory because two centuries of political development encompass multiple institutional ruptures whose long-term organizational consequences can be compared.

This section introduces the Peruvian historical context required for interpreting the empirical analyses that follow. It first explains how Peru's republican history is organized into successive political frameworks derived from completed critical junctures. It then examines the organizational transformation associated with Peru's integration into the global economy after the crises of the 1980s. Finally, it explains why the ministerial portfolios analyzed in this study constitute theoretically informative organizational comparisons.

3.1 Political Frameworks and Critical Junctures

The first proposition of the theoretical framework argues that political frameworks shape the organizational conditions under which continuity becomes possible. Because political frameworks are latent historical constructs rather than directly observable entities, they require empirical operationalization before their observable implications can be examined.

This study follows the comparative-historical tradition of Critical Junctures, which conceives political development as a sequence of relatively stable institutional orders separated by relatively brief periods of exceptional political transformation. Rather than treating political history as a continuous process of incremental change, the Critical Juncture literature argues that major crises reorganize political authority, redefine governing coalitions, and generate institutional legacies that subsequently structure political life over extended periods of time. Political frameworks are therefore understood as the durable institutional environments produced by completed critical junctures.

Following the historical reconstruction developed by Lopez Jimenez et al. (2025), Peru's republican history is organized into six successive political frameworks bounded by five completed critical junctures and a sixth political framework associated with an ongoing critical juncture. Because the current political reconfiguration remains unresolved, the institutional legacy of this latest framework should be regarded as provisional.

Table 2 summarizes the political frameworks employed throughout the empirical analyses.

Although each critical juncture emerged from distinct historical circumstances, they share an important organizational characteristic. Rather than merely replacing governments or constitutions, each fundamentally altered the priorities, capacities, and internal organization of the Peruvian state.

The War of the Pacific exposed the near absence of a coherent national state capable of coordinating military, fiscal, and administrative resources, initiating a pro-

Table 2*Operationalization of Political Frameworks*

Political Framework	Period	Originating Critical Juncture	Dominant Political Legacy
PF1 – State Formation	1824–1883	Independence (1810–1824)	Failed national state-building; persistent caudillo politics; colonial institutional continuities.
PF2 – Oligarchic State	1883–1933	War of the Pacific (1879–1883)	Elite reconstruction under oligarchic rule; patrimonial state consolidation and restricted political incorporation.
PF3 – Power-Sharing State	1933–1975	Crisis of the Aristocratic Republic (1920–1933)	Tripartite political order involving oligarchy, APRA, and the armed forces; gradual incorporation of organized social actors.
PF4 – Democratic Transition and Crisis	1975–1993	Military Revolution (1968–1975)	Democratization following military rule under conditions of economic collapse, political violence, and institutional crisis.
PF5 – Democracy without Parties	1993–2022	Fujimori Settlement (1982–1992)	Neoliberal political order characterized by weak parties, electoral volatility, and sustained executive predominance.
PF6 – Current Critical Juncture	2022–Present	Collapse of the Fujimori Settlement (2021–2022)	Fragmentation of the neoliberal political order; collapse of executive-legislative equilibrium; intensified social polarization; uncertain institutional realignment still in progress.

Note: The political frameworks presented here constitute the heuristic operationalization of Proposition P1. They represent enduring political legacies inferred from completed critical junctures rather than directly observable historical entities. Alternative operationalizations are possible under different historical interpretations. Adapted from Lopez Jimenez et al. (2025).

longed period of state reconstruction under oligarchic leadership. The collapse of the Aristocratic Republic transformed an exclusionary political order into one increasingly confronted by mass political mobilization and organized social actors. The Military Revolution radically expanded the organizational capacity of the state through agrarian reform, nationalization, and the creation of new public institutions while simultaneously restricting democratic competition. The combined crises of terrorism, hyperinflation, and institutional collapse during the 1980s culminated in the constitutional settlement of the 1990s, which selectively reorganized the Peruvian state around macroeconomic stabilization and market governance. Finally, the current political crisis, initiated after the fall of President Pedro Castillo, raises the possibility that the post-1993 political settlement has entered a new period of institutional reconfiguration whose long-term legacy remains uncertain.

These historical transformations are interpreted here not primarily as constitutional or electoral episodes, but as successive reorganizations of the state itself. Each political framework redistributed political authority, altered governing priorities, ex-

panded or contracted organizational capacities, and redefined the conditions under which governmental organizations operated. From the perspective of the present theoretical framework, these organizational transformations constitute the relevant historical environments within which opportunities for organizational continuity, organizational knowledge accumulation, and institutional learning are expected to vary.

Accordingly, the political frameworks summarized in Table 2 constitute the empirical operationalization of Proposition P1. They identify the historically distinct organizational environments within which the observable implications of the theoretical framework are examined in the remainder of the paper.

3.2 Globalization and the Selective Reconstruction of the State

The transition from the fourth to the fifth political framework represents a qualitatively different type of institutional transformation. Earlier critical junctures primarily reorganized domestic political coalitions, expanded state capacity, or redistributed political authority. The institutional settlement that emerged after the crises of the 1980s, however, fundamentally redefined how the Peruvian state organized itself to govern within an increasingly globalized political economy.

Importantly, Peru's integration into international markets during the 1990s was not historically unprecedented. Throughout both the colonial and republican periods, successive governments repeatedly adopted outward-oriented development strategies based upon primary exports, liberal economic policies, and close integration with the dominant international economic powers of their time. Similar patterns characterized the Bourbon reforms of the late colonial period, the guano economy of the nineteenth century, the Aristocratic Republic, and the liberal economic orientation reestablished during the 1950s. In this sense, the post-1990 reforms represented not Peru's first encounter with globalization, but the latest historical expression of a long-standing outward-oriented development strategy.

What distinguished the post-1990 political framework was therefore not the adoption of liberal economic policies themselves, but the unprecedented organizational response through which those policies were implemented. The combined crises of terrorism, hyperinflation, fiscal collapse, external indebtedness, and the disintegration of the traditional party system produced an exceptional political opportunity for institutional redesign. The severity of the crisis allowed reforms that would probably have been politically infeasible under normal democratic conditions. Unlike previous episodes of economic liberalization, macroeconomic stabilization and structural reform were implemented almost simultaneously, producing a rapid and far-reaching reconstruction of the Peruvian state.

This reconstruction was highly selective. The state largely abandoned its entrepreneurial role through extensive privatization, reduced or decentralized numerous public functions, and substantially deregulated labor, capital, and product markets. At the same time, however, organizations responsible for macroeconomic governance were deliberately strengthened. Fiscal authority became increasingly centralized

within the Ministry of Economy and Finance; budgetary institutions were modernized; tax administration was reinforced; monetary autonomy was consolidated; and progressively more formalized fiscal rules and planning procedures were introduced. Rather than simply reducing the size of the state, the reforms concentrated organizational authority, technical expertise, and administrative capacity within a relatively small set of institutions responsible for preserving macroeconomic stability.

The subsequent commodity boom reinforced this new institutional architecture. Rising exports, increasing foreign investment, and sustained economic growth provided the fiscal resources and political legitimacy necessary for the new organizational arrangements to persist across successive governments. Importantly, however, Peru's economic success did not eliminate its structural dependence on primary exports or external financial conditions. On the contrary, continued integration into global markets made credible macroeconomic management increasingly indispensable. Organizations responsible for fiscal policy, public investment, debt management, and macroeconomic programming therefore became progressively more valuable not because economic problems had disappeared, but because the country's development strategy depended upon managing persistent external constraints.

From the perspective developed in this paper, these historical developments have direct organizational implications. The post-1990 settlement can be interpreted as an organizational response to lessons accumulated across repeated historical episodes of outward-oriented development. Rather than repeatedly reconstructing macroeconomic capacity after successive political crises, governments increasingly concentrated technical expertise, institutional memory, administrative routines, and policy credibility within organizations responsible for macroeconomic governance. In this sense, the reforms represented not simply a change in economic policy but a selective reconstruction of the organizational architecture of the state.

This interpretation provides the historical motivation for Proposition P2. Protective belts are not understood as legal privileges granted to particular ministries, nor as guarantees of individual ministerial tenure. Rather, they emerge when the organizational knowledge embedded within particular governmental organizations becomes sufficiently valuable that repeated disruption imposes increasingly high political, administrative, or economic costs. The post-1993 political framework therefore created the historical conditions under which stronger protective arrangements could plausibly emerge around organizations responsible for macroeconomic governance.

The observable implication follows directly. If the selective reconstruction of the state concentrated organizational knowledge within macroeconomic institutions, those organizations should exhibit greater organizational continuity than organizations whose primary function remains political coordination or the management of recurrent political crises. The following subsection explains why the Ministry of Economy and Finance and the Presidency of the Council of Ministers constitute the principal organizational comparison through which this implication is examined.

3.3 Why These Ministerial Portfolios?

The theoretical framework developed in this paper concerns the organizational conditions under which knowledge may accumulate rather than the careers of individual ministers. Consequently, the empirical analysis does not attempt to compare all ministerial portfolios equally. Instead, it focuses on governmental organizations that occupy distinct positions within the organizational architecture of the Peruvian state and therefore represent different observable implications of Propositions P2 and P3.

The principal comparison concerns the Ministry of Economy and Finance (MEF) and the Presidency of the Council of Ministers (PCM). Both occupy central positions within the executive branch, yet they perform fundamentally different organizational functions.

The PCM constitutes the government's principal organization for political coordination. It articulates cabinet action, negotiates with Congress, manages inter-ministerial conflicts, and preserves the political viability of the executive. Precisely because it operates at the intersection of governmental coordination and political conflict, it is also the organization most directly exposed to recurrent political crises. Cabinet reshuffles, legislative confrontations, presidential scandals, and episodes of social unrest frequently culminate in the replacement of the Prime Minister without necessarily altering the broader organizational structure of government. In organizational terms, the PCM functions as the executive's principal political shock absorber. Political instability is absorbed through changes in leadership while preserving the government's capacity to continue operating.

The organizational role of the MEF is fundamentally different. Rather than coordinating political coalitions, the ministry coordinates the state's macroeconomic governance. As discussed in the previous subsection, the organizational reconstruction initiated during the 1990s progressively concentrated fiscal authority, budgetary management, debt administration, macroeconomic programming, and public investment within the MEF. These responsibilities depend upon specialized technical expertise, accumulated organizational routines, standardized procedures, and institutional memory developed over time. Unlike political coordination, whose priorities may legitimately change in response to political circumstances, macroeconomic governance derives much of its effectiveness from organizational continuity, policy credibility, and the cumulative preservation of explicit knowledge.

Importantly, the argument is not that the MEF became politically autonomous or immune to democratic accountability. Ministers continued to be appointed and dismissed by elected governments, and macroeconomic policy remained subject to political contestation. Rather, the claim is organizational. If the post-1990 settlement selectively strengthened macroeconomic institutions, then the organizational knowledge embedded within the MEF became progressively more costly to disrupt. From the perspective of the theoretical framework developed in this paper, the MEF therefore constitutes the most plausible organizational setting in which a protective belt might emerge.

Three additional ministries are incorporated to provide organizational benchmarks rather than direct theoretical contrasts. The Ministry of the Interior represents the state's coercive and internal security functions, whose continuity has historically been shaped by terrorism, crime, police reform, and public order. The Ministries of Health and Education represent two of the state's largest providers of public goods and address policy areas that consistently rank among citizens' principal concerns. Although these organizations also require organizational learning and accumulated expertise, they were not selectively reconstructed during the post-1990 reforms in the same manner as the macroeconomic sector.

Together, these five portfolios represent contrasting organizational functions rather than merely different policy domains. The PCM represents political coordination under conditions of continuous political exposure. The MEF represents the preservation and application of specialized organizational knowledge under conditions of increasing domestic and international credibility requirements. Interior, Health, and Education provide organizational reference points operating under different political and administrative incentives. This configuration allows the empirical analyses to examine whether organizational continuity varies systematically in ways consistent with the observable implications derived from the theoretical framework.

The analyses that follow therefore do not seek to demonstrate that one ministry is inherently superior to another, nor that longer ministerial tenure necessarily produces better public policy. Instead, they examine whether Peru's historical trajectory exhibits the patterns of organizational continuity that the deductive framework suggests should emerge when political frameworks selectively preserve organizations responsible for strategically valuable forms of organizational knowledge.

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